

Unit 3 – Section 2: Business Growth

Exam Patterns & Trends (2019 – 2025)

Overview of Exam Patterns

Mark Type	Typical Command Words	Frequency	Focus Areas
4 marks	Define / Explain / Construct	Every Paper	Definitions, calculations, or short explanations of growth-related terms.
8 marks	Assess	Frequent	Two balanced arguments on benefits or limitations of growth methods.
12 marks	Discuss	Frequent	Debates comparing two strategic approaches (e.g. organic vs inorganic growth).
20 marks	Evaluate	Every Paper	Wide-ranging evaluation on overall growth strategy, long-term sustainability, or synergy.

AO Weighting: AO1 (20%), AO2 (25%), AO3 (25%), AO4 (30%)

Topic Trend Analysis (2019 – 2025)

Topic	Year & Question Reference	Command Words	Trend Summary
Growth (Economies of Scale)	2019 Oct Q2b, 2021 Jun Q1a	Explain / Assess	Appears in most years as a short or mid-mark question. Focus on internal vs

			external economies and diseconomies.
Organic Growth	2020 Jun Q2a, 2022 Jan Q1b	Assess / Discuss	Regularly featured; focuses on benefits of internal expansion and slower, sustainable growth.
Mergers & Takeovers	2021 Oct Q3, 2023 Jan Q2	Discuss / Evaluate	High-frequency topic; commonly a 12- or 20-mark question evaluating synergy, risk, and cultural integration.
Reasons for Staying Small	2020 Oct Q2c, 2024 Jun Q1a	Explain / Assess	Increasingly common; linked to niche markets, flexibility, and customer service focus.

Predicted Focus for Jan 2026 Exam

Predicted Topic	Mark	Command Word	Likely Context
Economies of Scale	8	Assess	Assess the benefits of economies of scale for a large retailer such as Tesco.
Organic Growth	12	Discuss	Discuss whether organic growth is the most effective method for long-term business success.
Mergers & Takeovers	20	Evaluate	Evaluate whether mergers and takeovers create more long-term problems than benefits for multinational

Staying Small

4

Explain

businesses.

Explain one reason why small firms can remain competitive in niche markets.

Teacher Revision Tips

- Use comparison questions: Organic vs External Growth or Small vs Large Firms.
- Retrieval starters: definitions (economies of scale, synergy, organic growth).
- Run 12-mark “mini-debate” activities on risk vs reward of growth.
- Link with Unit 2 finance content (overtrading, cash flow, sources of finance).
- Apply real examples: Greggs, Tesco, Lush, Amazon, BrewDog.

Key Takeaways

- Growth-related questions appear in every exam series.
- Mergers & Takeovers are the most frequent 20-mark topics.
- AO4 (evaluation) marks are gained by balancing synergy and risk arguments.
- “Reasons for Staying Small” has appeared increasingly in recent papers.
- Inter-topic links: connects strongly with finance (Unit 2) and strategy (Unit 3 Section 1).